

Checklist:

Team Topologies – Org Chart Problems

Team Design Foundations

- ☐ Apply **Conway's Law** when designing software systems.
- ☐ Design **software architecture and team interactions together**.
- ☐ Clarify each team's **purpose and responsibilities**.
- ☐ Use a **humanistic approach** that treats teams as central to software delivery.
- ☐ Align team structures with long-term organizational adaptability.

Org Charts and Communication Flow

- ☐ Recognize that organizations tend to produce designs that reflect their **communication paths**.
- ☐ Do not rely only on the formal org chart to understand how work really happens.
- ☐ Identify the organization's:
 - ☐ Formal structure
 - ☐ Informal structure
 - ☐ Value creation structure
- ☐ Look for gaps between the org chart and actual communication patterns.
- ☐ Avoid excessive matrix management and unclear reporting lines.
- ☐ Reduce unnecessary communication paths.
- ☐ Define clear, intentional team interactions.
- ☐ Choose software architectures that support **team-scoped flow**.
- ☐ Optimize for the whole system, not just local team efficiency.
- ☐ Use team structures that encourage modular, decoupled systems.
- ☐ Design the organization only when there is a compelling reason.
- ☐ Develop multiple design options before choosing one.
- ☐ Choose the right time to redesign.

- ☐ Watch for signs that teams, responsibilities, or communication paths are out of alignment.
- ☐ Stay alert to future business, technology, and regulatory changes.

Cognitive Load and Team Boundaries

- ☐ Treat the **team**, not the individual, as the primary unit of delivery.
- ☐ Keep team size within effective collaboration limits.
- ☐ Limit multi-team groupings based on **Dunbar's number**.
- ☐ Match team responsibilities to the team's cognitive capacity.
- ☐ Avoid assigning too many domains, services, or responsibilities to one team.
- ☐ Establish clear team boundaries.
- ☐ Protect teams from excessive context switching.
- ☐ Ensure teams have enough autonomy.
- ☐ Give teams space to build mastery.
- ☐ Connect team work to a clear purpose.
- ☐ Change the team working environment when teams are struggling.
- ☐ Optimize for flow of change and fast feedback from running systems.
- ☐ Review whether current team responsibilities are causing delivery bottlenecks.

Overall Review Checklist

- ☐ Are team responsibilities clear?
- ☐ Are communication paths intentional and limited?
- ☐ Does the architecture match the team structure?
- ☐ Are teams empowered to make decisions?
- ☐ Is cognitive load actively managed?
- ☐ Are teams organized around value delivery rather than functions?
- ☐ Are dependencies between teams visible and manageable?
- ☐ Is the organization designed for speed and stability?
- ☐ Are teams able to adapt as technology and business needs change?

